

KIRSTEN OLDS

The University of Tulsa

Fannies and fanzines: Mail art and fan clubs in the 1970s

ABSTRACT

This article observes and explores the rise of a particular type of fan club – the fan club as an artistic form. It addresses why the fan club became a popular format for artists to appropriate in the 1970s in the United States and Canada, especially in the international correspondence art scene, where participants used the mail as a medium for circulating postcards, letters, flyers, self-designed little magazines and other materials. I contend that fan clubs were counterpublics that offered the mail artists an apt forum for the self-conscious creation of alternatives to the art world, the mass media and mainstream entertainment, so that they could work out individual and collective identities, in particular, the expression of queer identities.

KEYWORDS

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mail art
zines
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queer identity
John Dowd Fanny Club
counterpublics
Eternal Network
Les Petites Bonbons

The late 1960s and 1970s in the United States and Canada marked an especially fertile and flexible cultural and artistic climate, with artists collaborating in groups, forming self-run centres, publishing their own periodicals, and tapping into social and political movements. Excited by new opportunities engendered by technological developments and galvanized by their changing social and artistic milieu, artists continued to move away from working with conventional media, such as painting, sculpture and print-making, to embrace mixed media, performance practices, video and conceptual art. Many developed new, sometimes intermedia, forms of art-making. For some, this involved appropriating forms from the non-artistic world and framing them as art, drawing on the productive tension that resulted from the collision of different worlds or worldviews. For example dancers such as Merce Cunningham,

Tricia Brown and Yvonne Rainer incorporated everyday movements, such as walking, running and crouching, into their choreography, while artists such as N. E. Thing Co., General Idea and Image Bank adopted corporate language and devices – official-sounding names, letterhead, even storefronts – to critique and explore the instruments of advertising and public relations.

Within this period, the fan club emerges as a distinctive form embraced by artists. For example, the December 1972 issue of the artist-produced publication *FILE* references seven fan clubs, among them the Marcel Duchamp Fan Club West, Jamie Craig Fan Club, Wolfgang Feelish Fan Club and the Max Ernst Fan Club. One posting in the issue announces the John Dowd Fan Club and '[r]equests anyone knowing the true identity and/or whereabouts of the real Count Fanzini please apply directly to Box 45, Garden Bay'. Other artist-produced periodicals and mailings in the early and mid-1970s mention more such clubs, among them the Felix Partz Fan Club, Gary Gilmore Memorial Society and Scott Johnson Fan Club. In addition to these, pioneering mail artist Ray Johnson alone launched several, including those honouring Jean Dubuffet, Shelley Duvall, Claude Picasso, Spam Belt, Paloma Picasso and Marcel Duchamp. These fan clubs grew out of the international correspondence art scene, also known as the Eternal Network, in which participants from all around the world circulated postcards, letters, self-created publications or zines, and other objects through the mail, establishing connections with others with related interests or sensibilities. In the May 1974 celebration of the Eternal Network, a performance event known as the Decca Dance, even the proposed awards acknowledged the fan club as a trend with titles such as the 'My-O-My Fan Club award' and 'Carmen Miranda A Fan Club Award' (Morris 1974: 3). Most of this fan club activity occurred in the United States and Canada, although some, such as Pauline Smith's Adolf Hitler Fan Club in England, suggest that it had broader reaches.

So what was the nature of these 'clubs'? Of whom or what were they fans? This article explores those questions, as it investigates why the fan club was chosen as a medium by artists in this period, and examines how asserting the fan club as an *artistic* format helped artists in the Eternal Network position themselves with respect to the Network, to what they perceived as the 'dominant' art world, and to consumer society. We will see how the fan club enabled artists to appropriate widely circulating imagery and media in order to create a sense of community and to picture that community for others. This examination of fan clubs as art may also help to expand our understanding of the nature and roles of fan expressions more broadly in our contemporary culture, realizing how many do not solely exist within the realms of putatively 'low' culture, but may situate themselves variously along different continuums from 'high' to 'low', elite to folk, mass to niche, and so on.

The fan club as an artistic phenomenon has received scant critical attention in both art historical and fandom studies literature; it has not even been recognized as an artistic format, an oversight this article seeks to redress. The formation, or designation, more aptly, of the fan club appears to be an outgrowth of a much larger movement towards artistic collaboration in the period, and John Dowd (honouree of the eponymous club) explained his participation in the fan club as symptomatic of the times: 'to survive the 1970s [things] must get smaller. Where the 1960s were explosive, the 1970s are implosive. Everyone is dividing up into smaller groups' (Albright 1984: 223). The fan club differed from other collaborative models, such as artist-run organizations, collectives and multi-authored zines and artworks. Some clubs actually

had little to no collaboration at all (unlike artists' groups, where participants eschewed individual recognition to work under a collective name), had no members other than the founder, produced no public programming (unlike artist-initiated centres), and, moreover, appeared to be organized around an object of admiration, be it nonsensical spam belts, famous artists, members of the mail art network, A- or F-list celebrities, or historical villains. These 'clubs' were not fan clubs in the traditional sense. Most did not meet, or if they did, their meetings did not seem to relate to the star that was their ostensible *raison d'être*. To wit: Ray Johnson reported amusedly, 'We had a Paloma Picasso Fan Club Meeting. Lots of glamorous people came to that meeting ... They wanted to know why they were there' (Lippard 1999: 145). In the case of the John Dowd Fanny Club as well as many others, the meetings (when they occurred) were performance actions that also circulated as mail artwork. One such meeting, dubbed *Wait until Dark*, was billed as 'a fake meeting of the John Dowd Fanny Club ... in the form of a minor epic' that allegedly occurred in the invented Bum Bank, British Columbia, in August 1972 and was chronicled on the pages of *The John Dowd Fanny Club Fanzine* (Dowd and Count Fanzini 1972, Figure 1). An otherwise unspecified 'Leon' played the role of

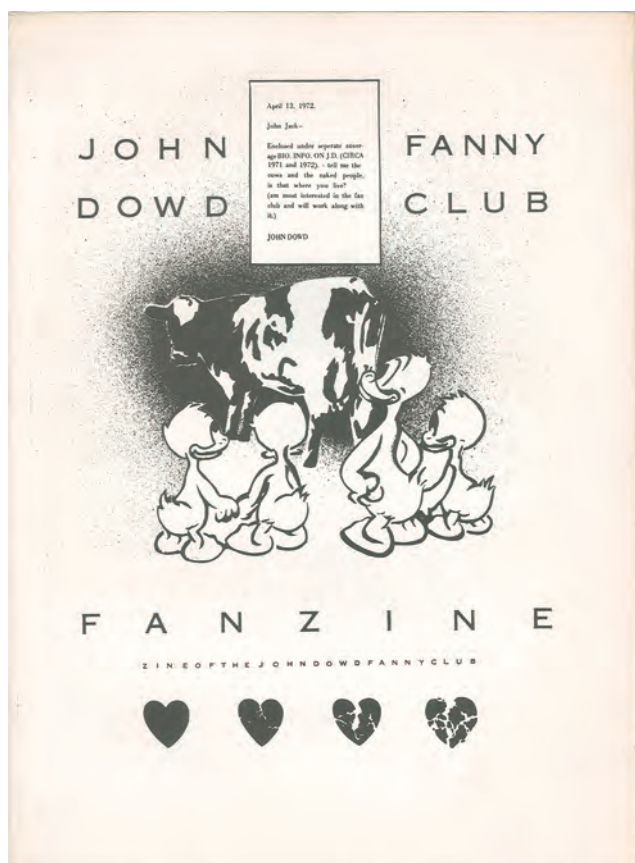


Figure 1: Count Fanzini and John Dowd, cover of John Dowd Fanny Club Fanzine, 1972 (collection of the author).

John Dowd. Other issues of the club's zine are dedicated to the occasion of the actual 'star' John Dowd – a New York graphic artist – visiting Vancouver, which included an autograph signing on the bums of his fans (Figures 2 and 3). The zine, with a circulation of 200 for the second issue and 700 for its third, was meant for the club's members as well as others in the growing correspondence art network and thus was picturing an event – the autograph signing – performed by its members to those same members. In these examples we see artists seizing several defining characteristics of fan clubs: founding and self-conscious naming, self-organization, celebrating and subverting established imagery and myths, and engaging in fundamental actions such as correspondence, advertising, publishing a fanzine or fan circulars, disseminating meeting minutes and autograph signing.

It was the *format* of the fan club, and its defining rituals and language, I contend, that the mail artists appropriated as an artistic conceit. Fan clubs and their related zines offered their members a means of creating their own culture. Through the expression of their admiration in postcards, publications and attendance at clubs and concerts, fans could communicate their own social visions and fantasies as individuals while also identifying with a group (Green et al. 1998: 34; Cagle 1995: 98). Through the zines they produced and



Figure 2: Count Fanzini and John Dowd, cover of Fanzine/Fanzini, c. 1973 (collection of the Morris/Trasov Archive, at the Morris and Helen Belkin Art Gallery, The University of British Columbia).



Figure 3: Count Fanzini and John Dowd, pages from *Fanzine/Fanzini*, c. 1973 (collection of the Morris/Trasov Archive, at the Morris and Helen Belkin Art Gallery, The University of British Columbia).

disseminated, the fan clubs showed 'that "ordinary" people could and did actively produce their own image worlds and did not just passively consume what the corporate image industry produced' (Watson 1994: 14). Thus the fan club was the vehicle for artists in the mail art network to publicly assert themselves as a cohesive social formation with shared interests and as an alternative to mainstream consumers, and this distinguishes them as fans from other media consumers, as Kozinets (2001) differentiates. Fandom creates another layer of mediation between consumer and the media, offering 'each fan a source of identity, power, difference, and mastery' (Kozinets 2001: 83). John Fiske explains fan culture's relationship to official culture, characterizing it as 'a form of popular culture that echoes many of the institutions of official culture, although in popular form and under popular control' (1992: 33). The fan club's hybrid status – borne of the dominant culture and thus capable of harnessing some of its cultural capital while also asserting itself as different from it – enabled artists to challenge what they perceived as dominant identity formations and redirect the power they conveyed. The fan club, thus, as a flexible and recognizable medium became, for its participants, an alternative to both the art world and the mainstream consumer sphere, which many artists linked to one another.

It is important to note that this idea of the fan club as an alternative to a putative 'mainstream' is chiefly a discursive construction. Fan cultures frequently construct the 'mainstream' as 'the Other' as a means to create their own subcultural authenticity, as Sarah Thornton (1996) and Marc Jancovich (2002) argue. In the case of Dowd and Count Fanzini – the editor and

1. Throughout this article I respect Count Fanzini's request to be referred to by his pseudonyms (Bum Bank/Count Fanzini/John Jack/John Jacks), in order to preserve the sense of this 'mystery person that no-one had ever heard of before, during or after' (Count Fanzini 2014).
2. The interview originally appeared in Jenkins and Hills (2001).

publisher of *The John Dowd Fanny Club* zines – they did operate largely outside of institutional tastemakers in the art world and in the mass media sphere, but they drew on and reproduced the icons of both and transformed them in their zines.¹ In creating the John Dowd Fanny Club they also rejected the cultural parameters of distance and contemplative aesthetics that elevated the consumption of high art and distinguished it from supposedly more easily digested, widely available mass media products (Greenberg 1939). Henry Jenkins observes such a divide between high art and fandom, explaining 'Fandom is not about Bourdieu's notion of holding art at a distance, it's not that high art discourse at all; it's about having control and mastery over art by pulling it close and integrating it into your sense of self' (2006: 23)². This, perhaps, was one of the appeals of the fan clubs for the artists in the Eternal Network. They allowed for the possibility of an artistic format that was ambivalent; they enabled artists to straddle the art world and the consumer sphere, to bridge high and low, and to use both as fodder for their reconsiderations of their worlds.

Several factors contributed to the adoption of the fan club as an artistic 'medium' in the 1970s. Many of the artists were raised on a diet of celebrity news and photos from magazines such as *Life* and *Look* that were seen as bastions of American middle-class mores, nationalism and consumerism. *Life*, especially, circulated the myths of consumer and celebrity culture, the notion that one's own 'life' was reflected on its pages. Image request lists published in the artist-produced periodical *FILE* and other outlets further indicate the thirst for star and consumer imagery. The lists functioned as bulletin-boards of sorts, where people could appeal to other readers for specific imagery. John Dowd, for example, asks readers to send '[i]mages of commercial symbols like the R.C.A. Victor dog, Elsie the Cow, Jolly Green Giant and Disneyanna' (Image Bank 1972: 16). Yet their *use* of this imagery differed from that of periodicals like *Life* and *Look*. Several members of the mail art network, such as General Idea and Anna Banana, even parodied *Life* with their own zines, in adopting its recognizable cover or items from the table of contents, but also including nonsensical, humorous, offensive, home-grown content that exclaimed a do-it-yourself ethos. Artists such as John Dowd prised the images from their original contexts and, by inserting them in a new context, modified the meaning of the original images to express their own concerns, ones that often revealed different values than those of consumer culture.

In particular, in the fan clubs that are the focus of this article, the alternatives they sought were distinctly queer. The club as a format provided a space of play that enabled participants to express queer ideas – such as content that ran counter to widely accepted values, and references to and depictions of homosexual acts – to strangers, packaging the club within a group identity and sense of camp excess (Olds 2013). Thus the fan club and its attendant zines offered the mail artists an apt forum for its members to work out individual and collective identities.

Artists also adopted fan clubs as an artistic format in this period because they implied a collective interest. They were, by virtue of the name 'club', a collective enterprise. Whether they were individual artists who worked under an alternate name that implied a collective body or those who actually produced work under the auspices of a group, all of these artistic practices controverted the authority of the individual artist, a legacy of modernism that had largely been upheld in the purist forms of conceptual art; for an art form where the idea is paramount, the originator of the idea is central to the

practice. The artists' use of pseudonyms reveals these individuals' and groups' active reframing of artistic identity to incorporate collaboration and circulation. The fan club thus issued a challenge to artistic individualism and underscored the social and collective values that undergird artistic practice.

COUNTERPUBLICS AND THEIR ZINES: CIRCULATING THE FAN CLUB

One tangible and circulating manifestation of these artistic fan clubs is the zine, the self-produced magazines published in limited print runs and distributed primarily through personal correspondence, small shops and barter (Duncombe 1997: 10–11). The word zine itself derives from 'fanzine', which emerged as a distinctive medium in the 1930s, created by science fiction enthusiasts as a means to share stories and critical commentary with one another. In *Fanzine/Fanzini* John Dowd explains to his correspondent John Jack (Count Fanzini) the nature of a fanzine:

It's commonly used among science fiction fans – and is a small magazine or zine as they call it that is published for fans only. It's an amateur publication most generally mimeoed with book reviews and comments and cartoons and large letters/discussion section. [A] rock fanzine is about rock and so on.

(Dowd and Count Fanzini c. 1973, original emphasis)

Circa 1975 fanzines resurfaced with early punk music, marking a second wave of production that many observers of the phenomenon have seized as a watershed moment (Duncombe 1997; Atton 1996; Stoneman 2001).

Yet the zine as a medium for artists became increasingly visible in the late 1960s and the early 1970s, several years before the advent of punk. Artists were attracted to the zine format because it was non-commercial but reproducible, inexpensive but capable of reaching far-flung audiences, and highly personal but still able to accommodate a variety of styles, imagery, content and voices. The amateur, self-publishing ethos of the zine appealed to those artists in particular who sought to evade notions of taste, training and standards that were seen to govern (whether they did or not) the practices of the museum, gallery and art journal. One group that was active in the correspondence art network sums up this perspective when they assert 'we don't want *any part* of the phony pig art establishment, which is as corrupt and commercial as the food or automobile establishment' (Albright 1984: 220, original emphasis). They equate the art world with consumer capitalism, and, in response, establish their own practices, like exchanging letters through the mail and producing zines, as alternatives to those in the corporate sphere that seek to render them 'target markets', transforming their interests into consumer desires (Duncombe 1997: 7). In adopting the fan club (if only in name), they nonetheless allude to and borrow from consumer culture to produce their own. This establishes a significant characteristic of their embrace of the fan club: it is both critical and celebratory, part Situationist *détournement* and part camp send-up. Rather than producing wholly new image worlds, they re-imagine existing ones, through fanciful and often dissonant pairings of images and text, puns and pseudonyms.

In rejecting established institutions and promoting their own self-created and published forums for exchange and discussion, these artists, I argue, establish the fan club as a form of counterpublic. Counterpublics, according to

3. Dowd and Count Fanzini's *Fanzini* is not the same as the later *Fanzini*, a small magazine from the 1990s in Spain. Dating some of *Fanzini*'s issues is difficult, as they do not all include dates in the zines themselves. A few dates have been suggested for *Fanzini Goes to the Movies*. Printed Matter says 1974, whereas Luis Jacob in *Golden Streams* puts it at 1973 and the Museu d'art Contemporani de Barcelona lists it as 1975 with a question mark. Because the December 1973 issue of *FILE* announces 'the recent FANZINI GOES TO THE MOVIES is an excellent [sic] follow-up to the remarkable Fanzine/ Fanzini by the John Dowd Fanny Club' (original emphasis), I concur with Jacob's date.

Michael Warner's analysis of the phenomenon, refer to the means by which people on the margins construct shared public identities through the circulation of discourse. Aware of their status as subordinate, counterpublics enable the exchange of ideas that are distinct from authority and represent a space for discussion that opposes forces of power or repression (2002: 113–24). This notion of the counterpublic resembles what Géza Perneczky (1993: 193–98) describes as 'counter publicity' in the context of mail art publications, although he charges that 'counter publicity' carries a propagandistic and conspiratorial bent, one that I maintain does not apply to the fan clubs and zines under consideration here. Recognizing the fan clubs of the international correspondence art scene as a counterpublic acknowledges a level of criticality in its discourses, through their appropriation and inversion of standard language, mainstream imagery and mass media formats. Sociologist and media historian Stephen Duncombe encourages this sentiment when he lauds zines for promoting a 'radically democratic and participatory ideal of what culture and society might be ... *ought* to be' (1997: 7, original emphasis and ellipsis). Whether fanzines made good or not on their utopian potential is not the concern here. What is significant is that bound up with the zine form itself is its status as an alternative. Prolific mail artist Klaus Groh seizes on this notion when he claims,

The work of the alternative group is, in our contemporary world, not only accepted; it is vital. ... The result of work is not important; it is the alternative action as a process of decisions, as examples for potential action, which are crucial and valuable, and which must be respected.

(1984: 71)

In adopting the fan club format and making zines, artists decided to 'make [their] own culture and stop consuming that which is made for' them, and that decision establishes the form as a corrective (Duncombe 1997: 7). To understand how these fan clubs function, let us look at the John Dowd Fanny Club and closely related Network practices with respect to several characteristics of counterpublics: their reflexivity, address to strangers, oppositional discourse, discursive self-formation and construction of an alternative world.

Through their participation in the Eternal Network, Count Fanzini and John Dowd came to collaborate on the John Dowd Fanny Club and its related zines. Prior to their joint ventures, neither had much of an established solo career as an artist. Dowd had produced several zines on his own, including *The Star*, in which pictures of 'Brian Jones, Mick Jagger, Guru's and telescopes are cut and pasted into a collage of fan-dom', *Supplement Wristwatch*, *Peter Rabbit's Birthday*, *Summertime Supplement* and *Disney Boys Deliverance* (Art Metropole n.d.) From 1972 to 1975, Count Fanzini (sometimes as Bum Bank and/or John Jack) and Dowd produced four issues of the club's 'fanzine' which became known as *Fanzini: The John Dowd Fanny Club Fanzine* (1972, 10 pages), which appeared in the periodical *IS.*, although some offprints circulated separately as well; *Fanzine/Fanzini* (c. 1973, spiral bound, approximately 180 pages); *Fanzini Goes to the Movies* (1973, glue bound, approximately 128 pages, Figure 4); and *Fanzini '75* (1975, staple bound, 90 pages, Figure 5).³ They also wrote letters on the verso of photocopied collaged pages from the published zines and compiled individualized, assembled packets for correspondents within the Eternal Network, so the imagery and text in the *Fanzini* publications circulated independently of the zines (and pointed back to them

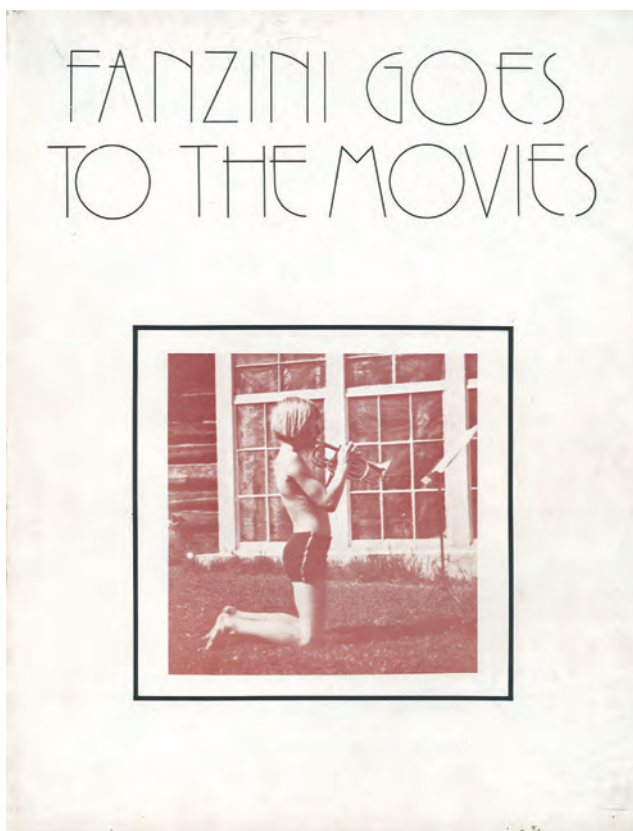


Figure 4: Count Fanzini and John Dowd, cover of *Fanzini Goes to the Movies*, 1973 (collection of the author).

at the same time). After their collaboration ended, Count Fanzini produced on his own another issue of *Fanzini* in 1976, with support from the Long Beach Museum of Art.

The zine format was an especially apt vehicle for collaboration. It enabled Dowd and Count Fanzini to exchange, publicize and spin-off one another's work, the latter calling to mind similar practices in television and movies. The pseudonym 'Count Fanzini' alluded to Telly Savalas' character Count Valeriano de Fanzini on the television programme and related movies *The Man from U.N.C.L.E.* The postal system facilitated their collaboration, as they were geographically separated by thousands of miles and international borders, with Dowd in New York, and the Count residing in Garden Bay, British Columbia, a remote locale off of Canada's Sunshine Coast, accessible only by boat or plane – a reminder of one of the tag lines of the image request lists: 'Your letters conquer time and space!' The locations – New York, Toronto, Vancouver, Mexico City, London and Australia – of others acknowledged as John Dowd Fanny Club 'officers' on *Fanzini's* masthead suggest the international reach of the club and its use of the Network to expand its circulation.

Reflexivity is an important characteristic of counterpublics, which are discursively formed, whereby the self-conscious address of strangers serves



Figure 5: Count Fanzini and John Dowd, cover of *Fanzini '75*, 1975 (collection of the author).

to bring about a collective body the authors and readers understand as a public. In *Fanzine/Fanzini*, Dowd and John Jack/the Count [Fanzini] nod to the origins of the zine itself by reproducing on its pages the letters they wrote to one another that detail the process of forming their fan club and zine. They reinforce the idea of reflexive circularity in their salutations and closings – John/love John – made possible because they share given first names. But their emphasis on process, discourse and exchange was not limited to their *Fanzini* issues; *FILE* also printed correspondence among John Jack, Dowd and members from General Idea, the group responsible for *FILE* (Figure 6). Such exchanges demonstrate the ways in which zines served as public indexes of what otherwise would have been private Networked activity. This is an important distinction. Their dissemination of their work and publicity in outlets other than *Fanzini* alone (such as in *IS* and *FILE*) was critical. They used *FILE*'s relatively wide circulation – between 3000 and 5000 copies – and its status as the Network's main organ, especially in Canada, to hype their Fanny Club and to promote their own involvement in the Network on *FILE*'s various lists, reviews and advertisement sections. This activity enabled them to reach new audiences, with some 920 entries listed in the artists' directory in *FILE* in 1974. Count Fanzini and John Dowd also reproduced on *FILE*'s



by all means 'our own magazine' is a great idea and what (I think) it's all about. If the FILE thing comes through that's great too. I think an important thing to remember is saturation – media assault on all fronts – you know what I mean.

They borrow a tactic most often used in celebrity publicity – ‘media saturation’ – and acknowledge their own zine as valid ‘media’ at the same time, revealing the ways in which they drew on existing strategies from the consumer world or cultural ‘mainstream’ in order to promote and validate their own status (see Jancovich 2002 for this dynamic with respect to cult films).

Artist-adopted fan clubs such as the John Dowd Fanny Club marked their discourse as oppositional, signalling their difference from both mainstream publics and other fan clubs. One of the primary ways in which this difference manifests itself is in the members' adoption of pseudonyms. For example,

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They were conjunctive devices, nodes that linked individuals and artworks in this new era of 'connectivity' (to quote Lawrence Alloway's 1966 description).

Some of the puns were coded as queer with game becoming 'gayme', 'miss' as the lisped 'myth' and 'mistaken' as 'mythtaken'. A whole subset of these, while not expressly gay, invoked various terms for, well, rear ends: 'arse' for 'art', 'fanny' for 'fan', 'procrasstination' for 'procrastination' and 'Bunshine' or 'Bumshine' for 'Sunshine'. These permutations suggest a queering of the discourse by Dowd, Count Fanzini and others in the Network, specifically via camp playfulness and bon mots. Their club name alone – John Dowd Fanny Club – retains the connection to the 'fan club' while also suggesting their own refiguring of the notion of the club, as humorous, absurdist, queer and oppositional. These linguistic tricks encouraged in participants the feeling of being part of a community, but also the attendant status of remaining outside discursive mainstreams, which helped create the Eternal Networks' zine artists as a counterpublic, and, in the case of the zines *FILE*, *Fanzini* and *Egozine*, as queer counterpublics.

Dowd and Count Fanzini's fan club plays with this very notion of the queer counterpublic. The 'fan club' as format likely appealed to the two artists because it lacked the connotations of activism and militancy of other social organizations of the period (and of the preceding years of anti-war, anti-establishment, ecological and social justice movements). Members of the Eternal Network from General Idea to Les Petites Bonbons moved away from activist organizations in the 1970s, part of a new 'utopia limited', as literary historian Marianne DeKoven terms it, which characterized the decade (DeKoven 2004; Olds 2009, 2013). Related artistic groups without explicit mention of 'fan' in their names, such as the New Era Social Club (also referred to as Nude Era Social Club), Mutual Admiration Society and Friends of the Reasonable Hand Drawn Facsimile, corroborate the artistic interest in the 'club' as an expression of mainstream social values. Yet such clubs, seemingly so humdrum in white, heterosexual communities (whether rural, suburban, or urban), were often off-limits for queer individuals or those perceived to be or self-consciously positioned as outside the norms of their cultural environment. Michael Morris, who co-founded the group Image Bank and worked under many pseudonyms, among them 'Marcel Idea', affirmed this sense of using an established form to subvert it when he opined, 'I think the personae and mythologies were a necessary step in making such a radical break with the existing roles and traditions: they created for us a world where the serious ground we were breaking could be taken as "business as usual"' (2002: 34). Morris' reference to 'business as usual' also expresses the ease with which these frequently subversive practices went unrecognized as such, subsumed within acceptable social formations. Perhaps as a result they lose a little of their critical edge or purchase (that they are, in the end, ambivalent about their own status as counterpublic), but they do not become entirely integrated within the mainstream.

Mitigating their potential for co-option is a sense of threat undergirding the fan club as social model. Joli Jensen (1992: 9) and others have noted the ways in which the fan was characterized by 'images of social and psychological pathology', and this sense, perhaps of being noted as different (rather than expressly pathologized), does contribute to the formation of the counterpublic. Those addressed by the counterpublic are, according to Warner, 'socially marked by their participation in this kind of discourse; ordinary people are presumed not to want to be mistaken for the kind of person who would participate in this kind of talk or be present in this kind of scene' (2002: 120). Thus the adoption of pseudonyms, particularly for Count Fanzini

as the ostensible sycophant (to John Dowd's 'star'), might also be motivated by a desire to protect one's identity against discrimination or homophobic targeting. Gay periodicals such as *Gay Power* adopted this strategy, using first names and pseudonyms in the masthead, to avoid identification of the individuals involved (Meyer 2006).

In *Fanzini Fashions*, a performance in New York in May 1975 documented by video, John Jack meditates on the inclusive/exclusive nature of clubs and the relationship of queer to heteronormative identity through the use of sexual puns:

Unleashed, the lecherous, loveless lad and me and he and who is he and who is he to me that I let him have his most esteemed membership in my most inclusive club. And the dues are paid at the pit of my throat. Forget it. A potential straight subscriber intones. I must have read wrong. I thought it was fan club not fag club.

(transcribed by the author from *Fanzini Fashions* 1975)

He equates oral sex with initiation rites and proffering dues for membership in the club, relishing the double entendre of the word 'member'. He acknowledges the 'strangers' that his counterpublic addresses and opposes, by mimicking what he imagines to be their response: 'I thought it was a fan club not a fag club'. His paronomastic substitution, spoken as if from the 'straight subscriber', emphasizes the potential of the fan club to turn dangerous/queer/counter/bad, from fan to fag (with the attendant negative associations of the latter term). It is precisely this tension of the fan club as both benign and pathologized social form that, I suspect, contributed to his and other Eternal Networkers' adoption of the fan club as format.

John Jack's parroting of the response to the club underscores an essential component of the mythology of the John Dowd Fanny Club – the relationship between the club and its public. We saw one aspect of this relationship with the epistolary formation of the fan club charted across the pages of *Fanzine/Fanzini*. Public discourse is essential to the formation of both the star and his or her fan club. It is the means by which the fan club is both brought into being and through which its identity as oppositional or different from the dominant discourse is shaped. Les Petites Bonbons, a group of Eternal Networkers who published *Egozine*, recognized the power of discourse to construct their public image when they include the aphorism, 'Everything they say we are, we are', in their group 'manifesto' they titled their 'bon bon mots' (1973: 12; Olds 2013). Their saying recalls historian Daniel Boorstin's (1962: 61) epanaleptic characterization of the celebrity, whose fame is a 'most perfect embodiment of tautology': 'the most familiar is the most familiar'. In sum, celebrities are known for being known, and, according to Boorstin, are products of the media. In Les Petites Bonbons' saying, the 'we' designates the Bonbons in the guise of the celebrity that is *described* and *defined* by the 'they' that are the fans. This is an idea that had traction across the Network: John Dowd broaches it on the pages of the zine devoted to celebrating him: "'A STAR IS REALLY INTERESTED IN HIS FANS (AND FANNIES)" without them he would be just another John Doe' (Dowd and Count Fanzini c. 1973, original emphasis and self-quotation). Here Dowd's word play signals his greater participation in the Network; his mention of 'fans' and 'fannies' alludes to his collaborator Count Fanzini, president of his fan club who was also known as 'Bum Bank'. It is Dowd's participation in the Network and the actions of the Count that have elevated him to the position of

'star' through the creation of the fan club in his name – they have transformed him from a private, anonymous John Doe to the public John Dowd. Thus for Les Petites Bonbons and The John Dowd Fanny Club, conceiving of themselves in the guise of the fan is essential to their own *artistic* formation.

STARS AND FANS, PRODUCERS AND CONSUMERS: SUBVERTING MASS MEDIA IMAGERY

This is an important reversal of some of the key tenets guiding (and privileging) artistic practice since the early twentieth century, if not earlier, namely notions of originality, primacy and individuality (see Krauss 1985). Identifying oneself as a fan, as John Jack does (he is, in a sense, the 'ultimate' fan, as 'Count Fanzini'!) codes the artist as a very different kind of producer than as 'artist' or even as 'star'. In some ways it places him as a consumer, although this is by no means a passive role. As Fiske (1992: 30) and others have noted, fans respond with 'semiotic productivity', generating meaning and pleasure from the objects of their fandom even if they do not actively produce new texts or imagery (and many do). The Count's understanding of the artist's role as a reproducer is underscored by his and Dowd's use of collage (acknowledged by some in the Network as related to author William Burroughs' and Bryan Gysin's 'cut-up' method), where they use the seemingly benign aspects of the fan club format to heighten the oppositional frisson of their activities and the content of their zine. In a page from *Fanzine/Fanzini* (Figure 8), they transform Mickey Mouse's lovable pup Pluto into an anthropomorphized lover, superimposing his licking grin over imagery of an airplane as erection (taking flight) and a woman's ecstatic mouth. That classic sexual fetish, the shoe, triggers the 'semi-heaven' state declared in the caption. Photos taken from society pages anchor the composition, creating an evocative dissonance – what kind of 'fan club' is this, exactly? Pluto is more explicitly queered in *Fanzini* '75 (1975) in which the same tongue-wagging face has been superimposed over an anonymous male model's naked bum. Another page of *Fanzine/Fanzini* (Figure 9) reveals images of music stars – Marc Bolan, Ringo Starr – and emphasizes their celebrity by drawing attention to their fans; thus fawning groupies kiss and grab at Ringo, while a photographer shoots T. Rex's glammed up frontman. The proximity of a line drawing of Betty Boop to both Bolan and the photographer dramatizes the singer's status as sex symbol, as an androgynous pin-up. Coca-Cola bottles, posed like band members, sell the connection between the manufactured soda product and the manufacturing of celebrity. The Count and Dowd's approach to collage conforms to Linda Hutcheon's appraisal (1989) of pastiche as a critical strategy of postmodernism, whereby it exposes the constructed nature of representations and problematizes their history. This repurposing and recirculating may indicate the limits of what is possible under an increasingly spectacularized society of late capitalism.

In another reversal, by adopting the fan club as a medium through which to express oppositionality, Count Fanzini and Dowd unseat the simple binary of producer/consumer, star/fan. In the page from *Fanzine/Fanzini* with Ringo, Bolan and the soda bottles, the photographer's direct address – both coincidental with and breaking through the plane of the page's surface – also implicates the reader/viewer in this relationship of manufacturing celebrity. Turning the lens on the readers renders them both fans and, now, 'stars' of sorts. This recognition of the fan gets at the heart of the fan-celebrity relationship, as John Dowd does when he reflects on the celebrities gracing *Fanzini*'s

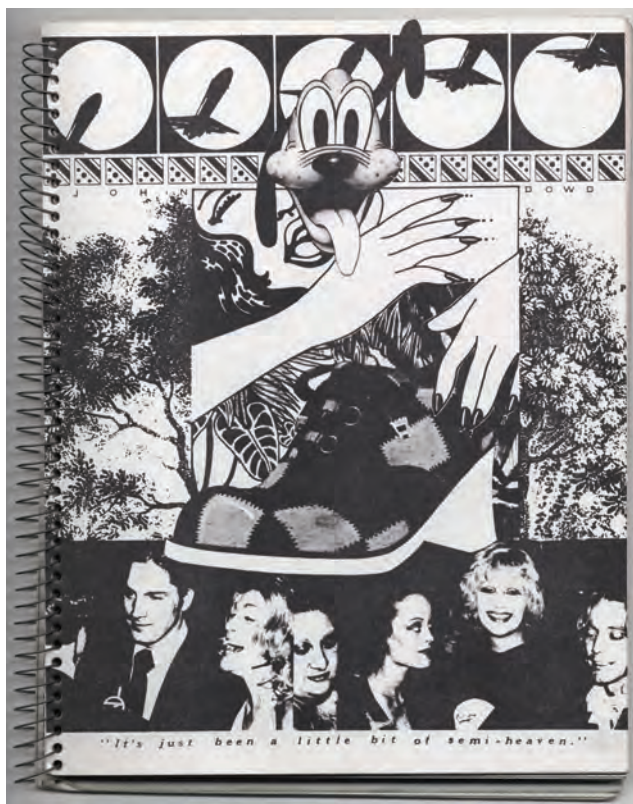


Figure 8: Count Fanzini and John Dowd, page from *Fanzine/Fanzini*, c. 1973 (collection of the Morris/Trasov Archive, at the Morris and Helen Belkin Art Gallery, The University of British Columbia).

pages: 'At the time – 1964–66 – I thought they were the heroes of our time. Now I realize a pop singer or a rock star are just our own projections – they were all just self-portraits' (Albright 1984: 223, quoted exactly as it appears in original). Dowd's insight acknowledges how both the fan's and star's identities are constructed through the practice of fandom. Fan admiration engenders stardom; it produced Dowd as a 'star' with his own fan club, after all. Stars equally shape the identities of their fans. 'We're fascinated by stars', Richard Dyer explains, 'because they enact ways of making sense of the experience of being a person in a particular kind of social production (capitalism), with its particular organisation of life into public and private spheres' (1986: 17). This mutual reinforcement of the star and fan is reflected in the letters in *Fanzine/Fanzini*, where Dowd explains his participation in the fan club in honour of him as 'a great way to exteriorize or get out of myself', and therefore to see himself as others might see him.

The fan club is, to put it simply, a representational device. The celebrity through the club is a mirror for the fans themselves, an image that the zines *FILE* and *Egozine* also promote. Dowd's exteriorization creates at least two versions of himself: the fan club celebrity and the New York bartender, father and mail artist, identities that he can, by virtue of the largely 'literary' medium

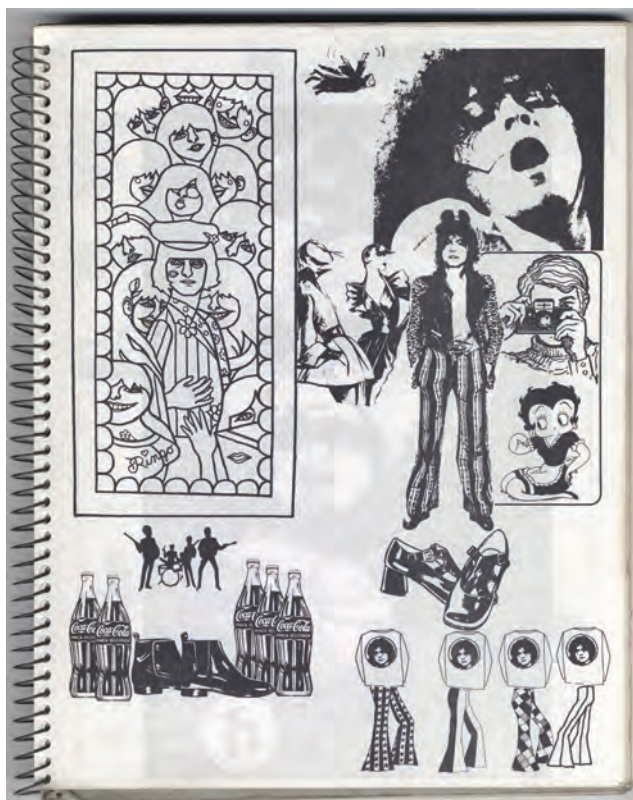


Figure 9: Count Fanzini and John Dowd, page from *Fanzine/Fanzini*, c. 1973 (collection of the Morris/Trasov Archive, at the Morris and Helen Belkin Art Gallery, The University of British Columbia).

of mail art and the zine, assert and de-emphasize at different times. In a letter printed in *Fanzine/Fanzini*, Dowd expresses concern about living up to the hype of the 'John Dowd character': 'Needless to say I am bit anxious as to how I will be able to handle the role of JOHN DOWD "in person"' (original emphasis). In the ongoing exchange of letters, John Jack quotes and inverts his collaborator's language, concluding: 'the John Dowd Fan Club is "a great way to interiorize myself, or get into us"'. Here John Jack seizes on the notion of reversal at the heart of the fan-star relationship, and of the collective/individual dynamic encoded in it. The use of quotation, which John Jack openly acknowledges by adding the parenthetical '(self quotation)' after the statement, helps to make this connection, as it shows John Jack as a fan reworking the language of the star to demonstrate the mirroring nature of fandom. The shift he articulates between 'interioriz[ing] myself' and 'get[ing] into us' also encapsulates the way in which *Fanzini* (and other Network zines) and the Eternal Network itself express individual identity with respect to the collective as counterpublic.

A cursory glance at the zines produced under the sign of oppositionality, such as issues of *Fanzini*, might seem to suggest that these fan clubs and zine producers were not actually creating alternate image worlds but instead were simply reconsuming and reproducing the myths and imagery of mass

entertainment. After all, much of the imagery and text in *Fanzini* stemmed from popular culture: Disney characters, movie stills and rock music publicity. Hollywood stars like Cher, James Dean, Josephine Baker and Jan-Michael Vincent posed and preened across its pages. Yet their juxtaposition with other images and text suggests another interpretation. To take one spread as an example (Figure 10): on the left page an aged, tanned and fit Pablo Picasso is pictured in white briefs, holding a robe in one arm and the collar of his dog in another; a black border frames the full-page photograph with the repeated white block text: FETISH. The facing page shows an enlarged, half-tone dot rendering by the artist known as Tom of Finland (a pseudonym for Touko Laaksonen). Tom of Finland's drawings, which had appeared in men's physique magazines since 1957, were by the 1970s openly acknowledged as homoerotic constructions that promoted an ideal masculinity as 'butch' or, for gay men, what was known as 'trade' (Ramakers 2000: 78). In this rendering, two heavily muscled men in uniform embrace one another in a virile form of erotic confrontation, with their bulging crotches accentuating the hypertrophied masculinity on display. The comparison here between the celebrated artist and these characters from Tom of Finland's vast *oeuvre* is contextualized on a preceding page (Figure 11), which announces the 'Battle of the Bulge' honour to be awarded posthumously to Picasso, acknowledged as the most prolific creator of '*objets d'arse*'. Here we are reminded of the Network's snubbing of fine art by dubbing it 'fine arse', with Picasso standing in for 'mondo artie' as perhaps the art world's most celebrated modern art exemplar. This 'fetish' spread objectifies Picasso, rendering him an '*objet d'art*' and '*d'arse*', in the punning sense as 'a piece of ass', or sexualized object, for both the zine

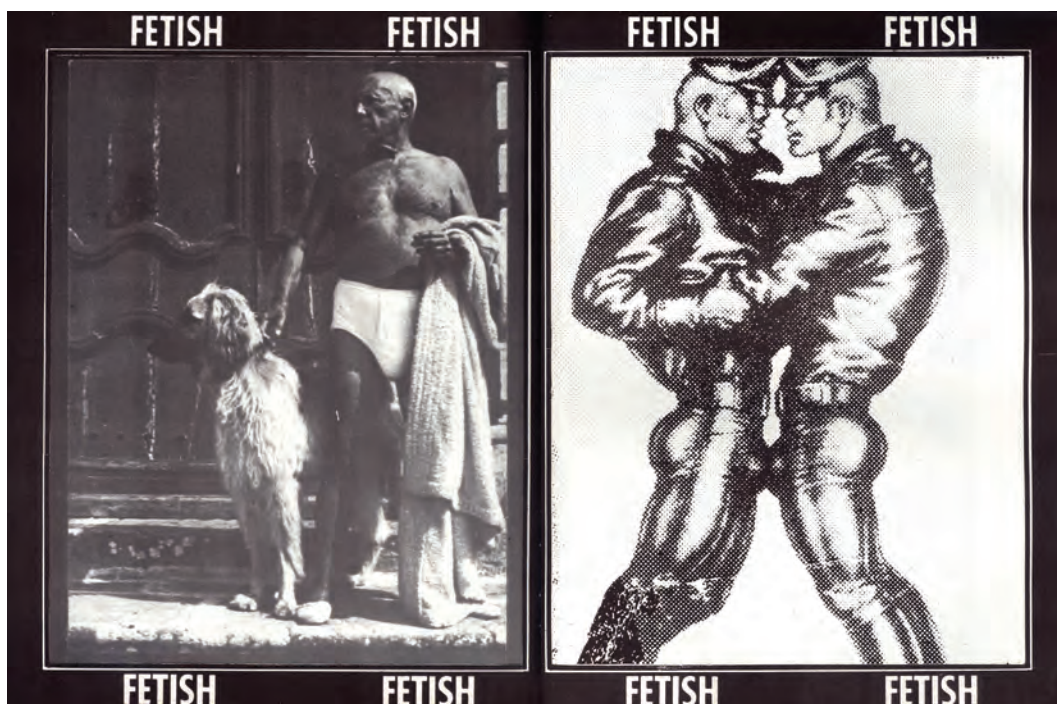


Figure 10: Pages from *Fanzini Goes to the Movies*, 1973 (collection of the author).

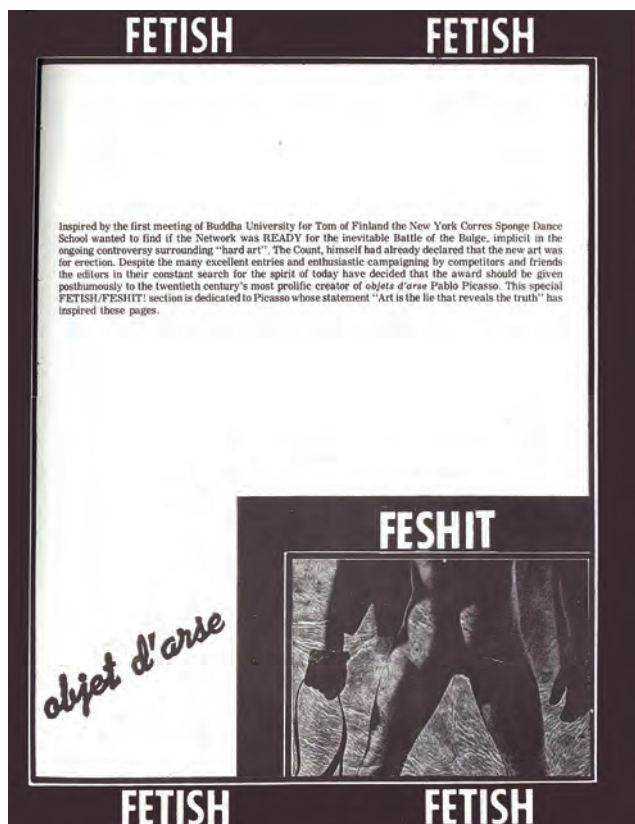


Figure 11: Page from *Fanzini Goes to the Movies*, 1973 (collection of the author).

authors and its readers. All of its readers, whether gay, straight, questioning, or other, are implicated within the homoerotics presented. On another page (Figure 12), Burt Reynolds splayed shamelessly as a beefcake beneath a billboard with cartoon character odalisque invites both desire and ridicule. The photographs of cultural idols across *Fanzini's* pages both present the stars for our visual delectation and unravel their allure at the same time.

Fanzini draws the worlds of fine art and entertainment culture into its ambit, and marshals imagery and myths from both in its formation of a queer counterpublic (or what *Les Petites Bonbons* refer to as a 'gay universe'). In a description that sheds light on Dowd and Count Fanzini's use of conventional star imagery, a queer theorist later explained his own fascination with movie stars, and especially the diva: 'I was not attracted to Hollywood stars because of their femininity nor did my admiration of them reflect a burning desire to be a woman ... Instead, it was their world, not their femininity, that appealed to me' (Harris 1996: 168). He elaborates, 'film provided a vehicle for expressing alienation from our surroundings and linking up with the utopic homosexual community of our dreams'. Put a different way, being a fan of Hollywood enabled gay men to identify with others in 'achieving a collective subcultural identity' (Harris 1996: 175). The desire to identify oneself as a member of a particular community recurs in much of the writing about gay



Figure 12: Page from *Fanzini Goes to the Movies*, 1973 (collection of the author).

identity and culture, particularly in the pre-Stonewall Era: in another example, the author, David K. Johnson (2010: 867), tells the story of Bill Kelley, a small-town Missouri teenager who, upon visiting Washington DC for the first time, carries a men's physique magazine – one in which Tom of Finland's work might have appeared – to identify himself as *simpatico* to other men. This anecdote suggests how fan expressions, fan clubs and zines allowed members to discover and collaborate with others who shared common interests: 'One thinks one's the only person liking something, and then one finds one isn't' (Higgins 1984: xiv). The communal assembling that the artistic fan clubs and zines offered was especially significant for artists who conceived of themselves as not exactly fitting into celebrated strains in the art world – the more cerebral modes of photo-conceptualism taking off in Canada, for example – or within a heteronormative consumer culture.

And yet *Fanzini* and other zines did more than just create communities in which gay men and others could identify one another and participate freely. Through the juxtapositions of imagery and text, they reveal Hollywood as a model for how ideas about gender and sexuality were constructed in society, target these images for deconstruction, and assert this as a site for the performance of their own network identities. We see both individual explorations – by Dowd, Count Fanzini and others – and collective ones, which construct an image of the fan club as well as the Eternal Network more broadly. The move between the individual and collective is suggested by the 'myself/ us' dynamic quoted

from the Count earlier. We see in tangible forms the multiple ways in which artistic identities are forged across the network, and constituted by it, through collaboration in projects like the John Dowd Fanny Club or the production of *Fanzini*, *FILE* and other zines. A truly 'networked' artistic practice materializes, in which social forms such as the fan club enable the production of new types of artwork. The artistic fan club emerges as an important site for the expression of 'queer' as a discourse, as a site for performativity and as a community.

It is especially fitting that present-day websites have acknowledged *Fanzini* as one of the top queer zines from the past century and credited it as a 'major influence on gay 70s culture' (Routoulp c. 2011). It reminds us of how the Eternal Network was an analogue precursor to the digital networks of the Internet, and how the types of networking and fan expression that we might associate with the Internet today were forged much earlier, through the will of individuals seeking to connect with one another and using fandom – as a particular mode of communication and engagement – as a critical strategy to do so. Finally, we can see from their example how it is more important than ever to form communities, negotiate our individual and collective identities in and through them, and make our own culture.

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CONTRIBUTOR DETAILS

Kirsten Olds is an Assistant Professor at the University of Tulsa, with a specialty in modern and contemporary art and visual culture. She is presently completing a book manuscript on the networked practices developed within the international correspondence art scene of the 1960s and 1970s.

Contact: School of Art, University of Tulsa, 800 S. Tucker Dr., Tulsa, OK 74104, USA.

E-mail: kirsten-olds@utulsa.edu

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